A Gaggle of Saints

By Neil LaBute

Silence . . . a young, attractive couple stand apart from one another, dressed in the evening fashion.

JOHN: **(Pg 35-36)** So, okay, there was this big bash in the city. That's what we came down for. This get-together. Couple churches together, I think, and meeting in the city. Ballroom over at the plaza.

SUE: People from high school were going. Seniors now, mostly.

JOHN: We're juniors up at B.C., so, like, there's still lots of guys we know, who we're still in touch with. Friends, you know . . . **(Pg 38)** It just sounded really great, weekend back in New York. Stop in, maybe, say "hi" to the folks . . .

SUE: **(Pg 39)** We all thought we could go down together. One car. Everybody wanted to, gonna be in the city at this hotel, live band and everything. . .

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Some of the most frightening moments in life are when you realize that a person you love and trust has been putting up a front the whole time:*
ACTOR: *The husband that comes out of the closet.*
ACTRESS: *Grandparents who get divorced after being together forever.*
ACTOR: *Discovering you had siblings you didn't know about.*
ACTRESS: *These things happen to "normal" people all the time. People are capable of anything.*
ACTOR: *In Gaggle of Saints, Neil LaBute introduces us to John and Sue, two Mormon sweethearts who tell the story of attending a formal dance in New York City.*
ACTRESS: *But it's what happens after the dance in Central Park that makes the unexpected frightening.*
TOGETHER: *A Gaggle of Saints by Neil LaBute*

JOHN: **(Pg 39-40)** And so six of us, a girl that's going out with this David from my fraternity, Karen's her name; I think. . . she was coming too cause she knew the city pretty well,

SUE: David said he'd drive and we're all picked up at three in the afternoon, Saturday.

JOHN: I'm rushing around, fighting for tuxedos, ten minutes to six, Friday afternoon! *(beat)* I ended up with a Perry Ellis. Finally. A size big, but I got one. . . looks okay, doesn't it?

SUE: It looked good on him. . .I had to put a safety pin in the vest, in the back of it, but it was really

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nice when he had it on. I had this dress I'd been saving. . . all black taffeta.

JOHN: **(Pg 41-44)** Kind of a cutaway in the front, what's it called? "Scalloped," in the front and no back to it at all. *(beat)* She looked great . . .

SUE: This was going to be a great party *(pause)* I could feel it. It was our anniversary. . .

JOHN: Last minute got her a corsage. White blossoms. Don't know what kind, but they were white. I remember that. . .

SUE: The softest pink, it was . . . John thought it was white, but it was really just the lightest shade of pink. *(beat)* And you know? He pricked his finger, John did. As he pinned it on me, pricked his index finger. . .

JOHN: Stupid pin!

SUE: A spot of blood, just a drop on his shirt. . . in a weird way it excited me. The blood. *(beat)* I mean, the bright of his shirt . . . and then this splash of blood on his chest.

JOHN: Didn't get any on her dress. Felt good about that. . . wouldn't want to ruin her anniversary dress.

SUE: Four years. . .

JOHN: **(Pg 45)** Believe that? Four . . .since summer of our third year in high school. Wow. . .

SUE: **(Pg 53-56)** It was going to be great. A really good evening, I could feel it. . .

JOHN: And we walk arm in arm. Man, feels so nice to stroll past all these people, I mean, rich guys, girl like that on my arm! Made me feel strong, you know? Powerful.

SUE: We've got nowhere to go. . . nothing but possibilities. The party's not until later. . .

JOHN: David's girlfriend, "Karen," takes the lead at some point, walking us through the park. . . over by that one bridge, the big pond? Moon's smiling down and all, romance hanging over a night like this out of some storybook . . . I really do love this girl. That's the thing that's screaming out in my head right then. . .

SUE: He was holding my hand so tight. . .

JOHN: A perfect night. And then, off to our left, there's this, like, patch of woods near the path. Comes this rustling. . . I'm not scared but it's night . . .what else can you do, girls with you?

SUE: I thought it might be some teenagers. We all started to walk a bit faster . . .

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JOHN: And two middle-aged guys, L.L. Bean shirts, come out of the dark. Smiling. And I don't need a map to tell me what's been going on *(pause)* I don't.

SUE: It was just two men. Walking along. . . no big deal.

JOHN: They were off in the park alone. And these smiles. One dude looks like my father, a little, it's dark but he had that look, right, that settled, satisfied sort of . . . anyway, off they head, arms linked together and nothing we say ever going to change what they are. *(pause)* [We] Dance all night . . .

SUE: I haven't danced like that in a long time. . .

JOHN: I'm telling you, I can't get that picture out of my head. Those smiles. I can't do it. . . *(beat)* but the party is great. It really is. . .

SUE: **(Pg 57-58)** I'd never been to the plaza before, I mean, past it, shopping and whatever, with my mom, but never to it. It was tremendous! So much glass. **(Pg 56)** They'd done the whole room in blues and golds with these great moons, these golden crescents handing above us.

JOHN: Like smiles . . .

SUE: **(Pg 58)** High white walls. . . *(beat)* the whole thing, though. . . the trip, dance and all. . .made me sleepy.

JOHN: Sue went upstairs to our room with Karen and Tim's girlfriend, Patrice . . . Said they wanted to take a quick nap, then we'd go get a bite. This was, like, maybe, one-thirty. . .

SUE: **(Pg 59)** I'm not sure what time it was . . .

JOHN: We hung out downstairs a bit, talked to some guys from home. . .David, Tim, and me. I was bored. You know. . .so I suggested a walk. "Let's head over to the park." We shoot over into Central Park, the 59th Street entrance. . . looking around, talking. Really dark in there. Only lights coming from the buildings, way off. Kind of exciting. . .

SUE: I thought I looked up at two, or two-fifteen. . . but I'm not sure. 'cause I kept sleeping. . .

JOHN: . . .and then I saw 'em. Both of them. Those guys. . . **(Pg 60-61)** They were saying "goodnight. . ." well, not ***saying*** it exactly. But kissing. Two grown men, standing in this public park in the middle of New York and kissing like something out of a Clark gable film. Arms around each other, and nothing else in the world matters to these two. . . hands all where they

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shouldn't be. I mean, come on, I know the scriptures, know 'em pretty well, and this is wrong. *(beat)*

SUE: All of us, we were sleeping so peacefully *(beat)* Did you know Patrice snores? She does . . . a little.

JOHN: You know, you read about it, right, and you live with it. Don't love it; don't condone it for the world. Still,live and let live, whatever. But this is ***flaunting*** it. I mean, we're in town ***one*** night, that's all, ***one***. . . and we got 'a witness this? *(pause)*

SUE: I'd known Patrice since kindergarten . . .

JOHN: Men old enough to be our fathers clutching at one another like Romeo and Juliet! *(beat)* I start to feel sick, I mean it, nauseous. Then a last peck on the cheek and one disappears down a trail, headed for the west side. He's gone. The other one glances around, taking in the night, I guess, big smile up at the moon. . . and he strolls over to this "men's room." 50 yards off. Concrete building, with the steps down into it. Whistling while he goes. . . he was ***whistling***. I don't even stop to think this through but motion the guys to follow me.

SUE: **(Pg 50)** [John and I] are getting engaged this summer, we already planned it . . .

JOHN: **(Pg 62)** I told the guys to hold off. Wait for me to flush him out, make sure no one wanders by. Our friend's legs, I spot, patiently sitting in a stall. Not a care in this world. I slip into the stall next to his, start fumbling with my belt; and like clockwork, this guy's hand comes up under my side of the partition. Pink fingers, wiggling up at me, imploring.

SUE: **(Pg 43)** The softest pink, it was . . . John thought it was white, but it was really just the lightest shade of pink. *(beat)*

JOHN: **(Pg 62)** I notice this thin gold band on his little finger, catching the light. *(beat)* Two minutes later we're standing near the mirrors and sizing each other up. Name's "Chet," he says, and I don't even bat an eyelash as he moves in, his lips playing across my cheek. I just smile at him. I see his shoulders relax.

SUE: **(Pg 43)** It was our anniversary. . .

JOHN: **(Pg 62-63)** Then I let out a whistle that sends him stumbling back. Tim and Dave appear in the doorway. Chet comes back from his fantasies, a flicker in his eyes, realizing no good can

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come from this. . . and starts babbling. Even got down on his knees and the pleading. Begging. *(beat)* Probably a VP at some bank and he's wetting himself like an infant.

SUE: (Pg 53) It was going to be great. A really good evening, I could feel it. . .

JOHN: (Pg 63) My first shot catches him just under the eye and he slams into a sink. With so many of us hitting, tearing at him, it's hard to get off a clean punch but I know I connect a few more times. Tim kicking him long after he's blacked out. . . *(pause)*

SUE: (Pg 69) Anyway, we are getting engaged this summer, for sure. Did I tell you that?

JOHN: (Pg 63-64) And then it's silence. Not a sound. And then, I'm leaning down, pulling that ring off his pinkie. *(beat)* I told you I noticed it. . . And that's how we leave him. . . *pause.* We all start, giggling, can't catch our breath we find it all so funny. We slip out, one by one, whooping it up like Indians.

SUE: The phone woke me up. . .

JOHN: We wanted to take the girls out to breakfast. Say they'll be down in fifteen minutes. . . *(pause)* We waited outside.

SUE: (Pg 65) I got the other girls up. . .took a minute, but I got them up. I felt really refreshed *(pause)* I did.

JOHN: Dave's walking around on the curb, talking to himself, and Tim pulls me aside. Wants to why I touched the guy. Let him kiss me. He'd glanced inside and seen it. But I didn't know, didn't have an answer. Isn't that strange?

SUE: It was so quiet in the lobby as we were leaving. I started tip-toeing out. Isn't that funny? **(Pg 66-67)** We met in front of the hotel, and I saw John's face. All cut up like he'd fallen. [He said he was] racing along the fountain out front, balancing on it, and slipped. Scraped himself up and blood on everything. *(beat)* Silly games. . . *(pause)* I was eating my French toast, when I notice this glint in my water glass. A spark of light. *(beat)* John'd slipped a ring in it! A beautiful gold thing. . . I loved him so much at that moment.

JOHN: Happy anniversary

SUE: It was a little big, but fit pretty well. Had this wonderful leaf pattern, all the way around. . . I kissed him there, in front of everybody, and he blushed a bit. We all laughed. I can't tell you

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what a wonderful weekend we had. . .

JOHN: We did end up taking the Amtrak back up. . .just Sue and myself.

SUE: It was my idea. . .the train. On the way back – I shouldn't even bring this up – a fight broke out. Well, not really a fight but this argument between a man and his girlfriend. A lot of yelling. She stand ups and starts pulling on her coach and this guy, I mean, just backhands her.

JOHN: **(Pg 68)** Knocked her up against the window, really hard. He'd given her a bloody nose.

SUE: I could feel John tense up, but the couple was kind of dirty-looking and they seemed like, you know . . . ***those*** kind of people. So I whispered to John to "let it go" *(beat)* and you know what? He didn't so much bat an eyelash. Just kept holding my hand and playing with the ring on my finger. That made me so happy . . .

JOHN: **(Pg 69)** And finally, as we tumbled along toward Massachusetts, I could feel Sue fall asleep against my shoulder. All warm. Protected. But not me. . .I couldn't drift off. So I sat up, watching the lights dance by, the moon grinning down. And you know, I started whistling to myself. I did. . .

SUE: I was asleep there on john's arm, but I'd swear I could hear music. . .

JOHN: Not loud, I mean, don't even recall the tune. But I was whistling. . .

SUE: **(Pg 70)** . . .this beautiful music as I was sleeping. Like the sound of angels calling us home. . .

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